MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION March 2026

FOURTH SEMESTER

MG4DSCMLM200 - UNDERSTANDING ART

Duration: 2 hours Maximum Marks: 70

SCHEME FOR VALUATION

Part A

Short Answer

Answer any 5, 2 marks each

1. **State the importance of Aristotle's Poetics. [U] / [CO1]**
   - Introduces concept of mimesis as imitation
   - Defines tragedy with structured elements clearly
   - Explains catharsis as emotional purification process
   - Influenced later Western literary criticism traditions
2. **Identify one major contribution of Michelangelo to Renaissance art. [K] / [CO2]**
   - Created David sculpture showing ideal human form
   - Painted Sistine Chapel ceiling with biblical scenes
   - Mastered realistic human anatomy in artworks
   - Combined classical ideals with Renaissance humanism
   - Influenced later European artists significantly
3. **Identify a key feature of Expressionist art. [K] / [CO3]**
   - Focus on emotional and psychological expression
   - Distorted forms to convey inner feelings
   - Use of bold, unnatural colour schemes
   - Example: Edvard Munch's The Scream
4. **Identify the architectural style of Khajuraho temples. [K] / [CO4]**
   - Built in North Indian Nagara architectural style
   - Rich sculptural carvings on exterior walls
   - Erotic and symbolic figures prominently depicted
   - Example: Kandariya Mahadeva Temple complex
5. **Identify the role of Roman art in shaping Early Christian art. [U] / [CO2]**
   - Use of arches and domes in buildings
   - Influenced realistic human figure representation
   - Mosaic decoration techniques widely continued
   - Example: Early Christian catacomb paintings, Sarcophagi
6. **Mention two Impressionist techniques. [K] / [CO3]**
   - Use of loose and visible brush strokes
   - Capturing changing effects of natural light
   - Painting outdoors in plein air method
   - Example: Monet's Impression, Sunrise painting
7. **State the difference between Mughal and Rajput miniatures. [An] / [CO4]**
   - Mughal miniatures show realistic portrait style
   - Rajput paintings use bold decorative colour schemes
   - Mughal themes include royal court life scenes
   - Rajput themes focus on mythology and romance
   - Example: Akbarnama vs Krishna Lila paintings

2x5=10

Part B

One Paragraph Answer

Answer any 6, 5 marks each

8. **Discuss the importance of manuscripts in Indian art. [U] / [CO4]**
   - Preserved religious texts like Ramayana and Bhagavata
   - Included miniature paintings alongside written content
   - Used natural dyes and handmade paper materials

- Helped transmission of culture across generations
- Integrated text and visual storytelling effectively
- Example: Illustrated Jain Kalpasutra manuscripts

9. **Analyse the role of nature in Romantic painting. [An] / [CO3]**
    - Nature represented as powerful and sublime force
    - Reflected human emotions and inner psychological states
    - Large-scale landscapes became central subject matter
    - Contrast between human fragility and vast nature
    - Symbolized freedom and imagination of individual artist
    - Use of dramatic lighting and atmospheric effects
    - Example: Turner's storm and sea paintings
10. **Compare mural traditions of Kerala temples and churches. [A] / [CO2]**
    - Both traditions use natural mineral-based pigments
    - Temple murals depict Hindu deities and mythological stories
    - Church murals represent Biblical narratives and saints
    - Temple style is more symbolic and stylized
    - Church murals influenced by Western realism techniques
    - Differences in colour palette and composition style
    - Example: Guruvayur temple vs Syrian church murals
11. **Explain Lokadharmi and Natyadharmi. [U] / [CO1]**
    - Lokadharmi refers to realistic representation of life
    - Natyadharmi represents stylized theatrical performance mode
    - Lokadharmi imitates everyday human behaviour naturally
    - Natyadharmi uses gestures, mudras, and symbolism
    - Both concepts derived from Natya Shastra tradition
    - Used in classical Indian theatre like Kathakali
    - They complement each other in stage presentation
12. **Describe the artistic style of Caravaggio. [U] / [CO2]**
    - Use of chiaroscuro with strong light-dark contrasts
    - Highly realistic depiction of human figures and emotions
    - Dramatic compositions with intense narrative moments
    - Focus on religious themes with humanized approach
    - Created strong emotional impact on viewers
    - Example: The Calling of Saint Matthew painting
13. **Describe the main characteristics of Surrealist art. [U] / [CO3]**
    - Depicts dream-like and fantastical imaginary scenes
    - Explores subconscious mind influenced by Freud theory
    - Symbolism represents hidden meanings and desires
    - Freedom from logical structure and realism rules
    - Encourages viewer interpretation and imagination
    - Example: Salvador Dali's Persistence of Memory
14. **Discuss the themes and subjects of colonial Indian art. [U] / [CO4]**
    - Depicted daily life and occupations of Indian society
    - Influenced by European academic art techniques
    - Included portraits of British officials and elites
    - Documented Indian landscapes, flora, and fauna
    - Combined Indian themes with Western realism styles
    - Example: Company School paintings in India
15. **Explain the function of stained glass in Gothic churches. [A] / [CO2]**
    - Served as decorative architectural element in cathedrals
    - Depicted Biblical stories for illiterate believers
    - Created spiritual and divine atmosphere inside church
    - Symbolized presence of divine light and glory
    - Enhanced aesthetic appeal of Gothic architecture
    - Example: Chartres Cathedral stained glass windows

[5x6=30]

Part C

Short Essay

Answer any 2, 15 marks each

16. **Explain the role of classical Indian theatre forms in preserving cultural and moral values. [U] / [CO1]**

- Based on principles of Bharata's Natya Shastra text
- Preserves epics like Ramayana and Mahabharata stories
- Communicates moral lessons and ethical values clearly
- Uses music, dance, and elaborate costume traditions
- Reflects social, religious, and cultural practices
- Promotes regional cultural identity and continuity
- Employs symbolic gestures and stylized expressions
- Encourages collective community participation and learning
- Acts as medium of informal cultural education
- Passes traditions across generations through performance
- Example: Kathakali and Kutiyattam performances

17. **Evaluate the symbolic and narrative qualities of Romanesque church art. [A] / [CO2]**

- Extensive use of symbolic religious imagery and figures
- Narrative relief sculptures depict Biblical events clearly
- Art served didactic purpose for common people
- Human figures appear stylized and less naturalistic
- Frescoes and mosaics decorate interior church spaces
- Portal sculptures guide believers entering church space
- Emphasis on spiritual message over visual realism
- Strong storytelling through sequential visual panels
- Limited perspective and anatomical accuracy in figures
- Reinforced Christian teachings and doctrines visually
- Example: Tympanum sculptures in Romanesque churches

18. **Critically analyze Abstract Art as a break from traditional representation. [An] / [CO3]**

- Rejects realistic depiction of physical objects completely
- Focuses on colour, line, and abstract forms
- Expresses emotions directly without representational imagery
- Breaks rules of perspective and natural proportion
- Encourages subjective interpretation by individual viewers
- Developed as part of modernist artistic movements
- Artists experiment with materials and techniques freely
- Non-objective art removes dependence on real-world subjects
- Challenges conventional definition and purpose of art
- Influenced later contemporary and conceptual art forms
- Example: Kandinsky's abstract compositions

19. **Discuss Indo–Islamic art and architecture as a synthesis of cultures. [An] / [CO4]**

- Represents fusion of Hindu and Islamic artistic traditions
- Use of arches, domes, and minarets in structures
- Decorative geometric patterns and arabesque designs
- Calligraphy used instead of human figure depiction
- Incorporates local materials and indigenous techniques
- Monuments reflect political power and cultural identity
- Gardens designed with charbagh layout principles
- Blends aesthetics from Persian, Central Asian influences
- Symbolizes cultural interaction and coexistence
- Influenced later Mughal and regional architecture
- Example: Taj Mahal and Qutub Minar monuments

[15x2=30]